
Paper 2, Option 2C.1: France in revolution, 1774–99

Overview

This option comprises a study in depth of the causes and course of the French Revolution, 1774–1799, a tumultuous period of change for the French people as they evolved from subjects to citizens in a maelstrom of revolutionary activity, war and constitutional experiment, and one that would inspire revolutionary movements around the world.

Students will gain an in-depth understanding of the causes and onset of revolutionary activity in France, and the subsequent political, social and economic changes.

Key topics	Content
1 The origins and onset of revolution, 1774–89	• The <i>ancien régime</i> and its challenges in 1774: absolutism and court faction; the <i>parlements</i>; the three estates; rights of nobles and church privilege; the impact of the Enlightenment and the spread of new ideas. • Problems facing France in the 1780s: rural poverty and urban food prices; taxation and crown debt; corruption at court; impact of the American Revolution. • The failings of Louis XVI and his ministers; Louis' character; financial reforms of Turgot, Necker and Calonne; attitudes to Marie Antoinette; opposition in the Paris <i>Parlement</i>; the Assembly of Notables and the revolt of the aristocracy. • The onset of revolution 1789: summoning and breakdown of the Estates-General; declaration of the National Assembly; significance of the Tennis Court Oath; revolt in Paris and the significance of the storming of the Bastille.
2 Revolution and the failure of constitutional monarchy, 1789–93	• Attempts to create a constitution, 1789–91: the Great Fear and the abolition of feudalism; the Declaration of the Rights of Man; the October Days and the impact of the march on Versailles; the reforms of the National Assembly. • The political environment, 1789–93: key political groups; the role of individuals, including Mirabeau, Brissot, Robespierre and Danton; popular protest and the <i>sans-culottes</i>; royalist support; revolutionary culture. • Breakdown of relations with the king, 1791–92: flight to Varennes and counter-revolutionary activity; divisions in the Legislative Assembly; the emergence of Republicanism; the impact of war with Austria and Prussia.

Key topics	Content
3 The National Convention, the Jacobins and the Terror, 1793–94	• Preconditions for 'terror': the significance of external threat; the impact of the Vendée revolt; economic pressures; political pressures, including the Girondin purge, Federalist revolt and Marat's death; the power of the <i>sans-culottes</i> and the Paris Commune. • Organising the Terror: the Committee of General Security; the Revolutionary Tribunal; the Committee of Public Safety representatives on mission; Watch Committees; the Laws of 19 March, Suspects and Frimaire. • The Great Terror 1794: the purge of the Hébertists and Indulgents; religious radicalism; the legislation of terror and centralisation; the extent and nature of the Terror in Paris and the regions; the role of Robespierre and St-Just. • The coup of Thermidor: growing economic and political fear; Robespierre under pressure; the arrest and execution of Robespierre and his supporters; Thermidorean government established.
4 From the Directory to Brumaire, 1795–99	• Problems facing the Directory: political violence, including the White Terror; political divisions; economic and financial pressures; popular protest. • The work of the Directory: the 1795 constitution; economic and financial reforms; martial law; attempts to control factionalism; Directorial terror; the extent of popularity and success. • Dealing with internal and external threats: the Verona Declaration and the émigrés; Parisian unrest; revolt in the provinces and reaction to conscription; the significance of war for the domestic situation, 1795–99. • The coup de Brumaire 1799: the Directory under threat; the role of Sieyès; the significance of the return of Bonaparte; the coup of November and establishment of the Consulship.